

In his paper “On a Certain Blindness in Human Beings”, William James states two interesting claims: first, that this *blindness* is one “with which we all are affiliated in regard to the feelings of creatures and people different from ourselves” (1); and second, that “we [have grown] stone-blind and insensible to life’s more elementary and general goods and joys” (6). First, I will expand upon what motivates this concept of “blindness”; and second, an attempt will be made at explaining how the “remedy” (6) James posits – that being “to descend to a more profound and primitive level” (*On a Certain Blindness in Human Beings*, 6) – can not only help us connect with Nature, but it can help us become less ethnocentric towards others.

So, what exactly prompts this *philosophical blindness*? Why does it seem easier to cast judgment on those that opt for living a different way of life? Aren’t we as a people supposed to be able to express ourselves freely? So then, why do we presume to know (almost instantaneously) the life of another individual, and then judge them, based on the way(s) in which they chose to express themselves, and if they are in tandem with our own ways or not? Does it stem from the idea that people seem fundamentally uncomfortable with what they do not know? Though when this uncomfortable feeling is recognized, it seems that it is because the person, who is uncomfortable, felt this way due to a mental pursuit of attempting to understand something they did not know; but ultimately what resulted was something like frustration. This doesn’t seem to be the case though if the person doesn’t care in the slightest to make an attempt to understand what is currently unknown to them, but instead just accepts that what they observe is something different. Now, when we do try to understand something that we currently do not, we tend to compare it with variables in our own lives and hope that a bit of sense can be made somewhere along the way. So then, an individual will be less likely to feel uncomfortable if they observe another individual expressing familiar properties that result in a recognizable lifestyle.

Therefore, it must be the case that one's disapproval for others springs from first, a recognition of unfamiliar properties with respect to their own, which is then followed by an attempt to understand the expressed properties of another, resulting more times than not in an uncomfortable feeling that then is manifested in the form of judgment or jealousy.

To complicate things a bit more, let us consider an individual that isn't aware that they are affected by this "blindness"; this is unfortunate as it happens to be a large number of people. How are they to know unless confronted in some way that they are being judgemental towards others, and for reasons that they (most probably) have assumed incorrectly? And even if and when they are confronted, is it safe to assume that they will evolve their mindset and perception of things? Not necessarily. So this brings us back to the question: *why do we need to strive for better eyesight when looking at those that live differently than us?* Or perhaps stated another way: *what benefit can one gain from attempting to see things through the eyes of another?* Well, James states, and I support, that "neither the whole of truth nor the whole of good is revealed to any single observer", but rather that "each observer gains a partial superiority of insight from the peculiar position in which [they] stand" (7). This then seems to imply that we can only progress and gain a more rounded understanding by learning how to "tolerate, respect, and indulge those whom we see harmlessly interested and happy in their own ways, however unintelligible these may be to us" (*On a Certain Blindness in Human Beings*, 7).

Now, it's important to understand that James is referring to the "highly educated class (so called)" (6), as to who has lost their touch with Nature, yet I extend this to every human-being simply because the lot of us are not considered to be "highly educated", yet I believe it to be true that we all hold a form of education in which can be beneficial if shared with the rest of the world. Though, for most of us it can be easily argued that we need to be put through a program

of primitiveness – to loosen the grip that our desires have on us. For this certainly cannot be what most of us would consider to be ‘good’. But we need to be careful when using this word ‘good’ since most of us have different definitions of the word, otherwise we wouldn’t have any examples of things that are held to be bad. What one may consider to be good, say for example, living a life filled with wearing custom clothing from top to bottom, and fanciful forms of transportation, another may consider to be distasteful. For, the wanderer that finds serenity whilst alone in the mountains, or the friend of the forest that observes as closely the falling of a leaf as that of a deer grazing – this may seem like the absolute worst way to spend time to many, yet it seems (more or less) that this is what James is hinting at, in regards to how we *should* be spending our time; at least some of it – more than we do now. He exhausts that due to “the clamor of our own practical interests”, one tends to become “blind and dead” to the point that “it seems almost as if it were necessary to become as worthless as a practical being,” – that is – “if one is to hope to attain to any breath of insight into the impersonal world of worths as such,” and from this, one can start to understand “life’s meaning on a large objective scale” (*On a Certain Blindness in Human Beings*, 4).

So then, much like the academic that is “trained to seek the choice, the rare, the exquisite exclusively, and to overlook the common” (6), so too is the one that lives a life not so fun and fancy free, and as a result they remain “far, far away from Nature” (*On a Certain Blindness in Human Beings*, 6). When James expresses the phrase “life’s more general goods and joys”, I want to highlight that he seems to be referring to Nature, yes, but there is also a sort of implicit sociological variable, in that he stresses our need for communication with others, and not only will this provide one with a more complete picture of life, but (hopefully) it helps to clear the fog

from their eyes, which in turn will lead to the acceptance of those that for whatever reason, live differently.

What then seems to be the reason for our disconnection with Nature? The obvious answer is due to a rise in technology and digital media. A large portion of people would rather experience the wilderness through some sort of digital device, as they can obtain a beautiful rendering on their screen, and all the while remaining comfortable in their home. Even when someone attempts to embrace Nature, let's say they are standing in a beautiful backyard with trees and bushes, and wildlife all around – the individual still submits themselves to some form of digital distraction (a desire), and therefore they are not truly connecting with Nature. We give the impression that connecting with Nature is hard. Yet to really experience Nature, all one needs is to simply be present, even if for a moment – a tyrannical task that most of us cannot seem to complete as this would require for us to have patience. When someone is present in their mind, they are patient; they can take a step back and look at things from a bystander's point of view; they are able to see the operations of the world, and with this, they capture not how things *should be* or how some may *wish for them to be*, but rather how things *really are*. An easy way to obtain an intimate connection with Nature: one can go outside with nothing on their feet and plant them in the grass and dirt; then they should observe the environment around them, whether with eyes or ears (or both), and hopefully the individual will start to understand that they are but a tiny part of the whole – that is life. What needs to be noted here is that Nature doesn't seem to resist us, but that we resist it. In other words, Nature doesn't make it difficult to connect with – it is seemingly always present, therefore the responsibility of strengthening our relationship with Nature solely depends on us.

So then, can it be that the same source that is responsible for us lacking a relationship with Nature is also responsible for the lack of relations that we have with others? Again, it seems that we would rather watch good deeds being done for others, and social interactions of various types being acted out, instead of performing the deeds ourselves or attempting to socialize with others, in a way that requires actual face-to-face interaction, and not screen-to-screen. And for the only reason that I can think of, that being technology and digital media providing to us a sort of stimulus that increases our property of instant gratification, causes our separation from both Nature and people. So if we really do desire to be given a form of stimulus, can we not shift it to focus on that of Nature, and therefore allow it to stimulate our senses, much like that of technology and digital media? Can we not agree that out of all things we find to be different from person-to-person, what we all have in common is that of being products of Nature; so from this it seems that Nature offers to us a sense of unity. Nature isn't necessarily waiting for anyone to connect with it, however it does seem to present itself to be the one thing that we as beings, and not just human-beings, can all share and benefit from. It's an open, organic framework for which we all use to operate, and because of this openness, it leads to a seemingly infinite amount of outcomes that manifest in the multiple ways in which we choose to express ourselves and live our lives.

For reasons which should be clear by now, a sincere connection with Nature can help lessen our level of ethnocentrism towards others, and it can also help us see the benefit in becoming more practical in our views of life. If we wish to lessen our judgements towards others – to drop any pre-existing assumptions and to be open to whatever the reasons may be for why some choose to live they way they do – while at the same time, further our understanding of how not one single person knows but only what they perceive individually, and that we should

seek to engage with others, whether or not because we have shared interests, but because we can learn more about life through these other perceived angles – the simple solution is to look to Nature.